Ali Quli Shaibani: An Uzbek warlord who was loyal to Humayun and helped establish Akbar's rule in Hindustan. Led the Uzbek rebellion, the first serious insurrection against Akbar

Bahadur Khan: Ali Quli Shaibani's brother and co-captain of the Uzbek rebellion

Ibrahim Khan: Uncle to Ali Quli Shaibani, participated in the Uzbek rebellion

Sikander Khan: Uzbek fief-holder in Oudh. Participated in the Uzbek rebellion, pleaded his way back to Akbar's court

Shahim Beg: A soldier in Humayun's court, then Akbar's. The great and undeserving love of Ali Quli Shaibani's life

Abdullah Khan: One of the many Uzbek warriors who accompanied Humayun on his return to Hindustan. Governed Malwa briefly. Joined the Uzbek rebellion against Akbar

Aides and Advisers, Commanders and Courtiers

Birbar (Mahesh Das): A minstrel who became one of Akbar's closest friends. Comrade-in-arms in Akbar's theological adventures. Died in a military mishap, leaving Akbar distraught. Lives on in popular lore as Birbal

Abul Fazl: Akbar's star historian, biographer, and, eventually, friend. Paid with his life for Akbar's trust in him when he was assassinated by order of Prince Salim. Wrote the *Akbarnama* and the *Ain-i-Akbari*

Faizi: Akbar's poet laureate and close friend. Abul Fazl's elder brother

Shaikh Mubarak: Abul Fazl and Faizi's father. An outcaste from the court ulema at the beginning of Akbar's reign, he rose to great power over time

Asad Beg: An old employee of Abul Fazl's, wrote an account of Abul Fazl's assassination. Led an embassy to Bijapur and introduced Akbar to the art of smoking tobacco

Abdul Qadir Badauni: Talented translator, enthusiastic warrior and bitter critic of Akbar's arrogance and heresies, of Akbar's favourites like Birbar and Abul Fazl, and of Akbar's self-important court clergy. Wrote a secret account of Akbar's reign, with all his complaints, as part of his *Muntakhab-ut-Tawarikh*